

PHYSICIAN SURVEY EDITION

The High School Student's Guide to Shadowing a Doctor

How to find a physician, ask the right way, show up prepared, and learn something real from every day in the clinic.

BY ZOHA WAHEED

Built from a survey of 43 practicing physicians. 2026.



00 Start Here

WHY I WROTE THIS GUIDE AND HOW TO USE IT



I'm Zoha Waheed. I walked into my first endocrinology clinic knowing little more than what Google had told me the week before.

Since then I have shadowed seven physicians across four specialties. Even once I had those days, I found it difficult to get the most out of them.

So I surveyed 43 practicing physicians about what stops them from hosting high schoolers and what makes a shadowing day worth it. I also read five peer-reviewed studies on how students learn in the clinic.

This guide turns what they told me into steps you can follow.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1

Get the day

Sections 1 to 3 show you why doctors say no, where to look, and how to ask.

2

Show up ready

Sections 4 to 6 cover paperwork, what to wear, and the privacy rules.

3

Learn from it

Sections 7 to 9 cover what to watch, what to ask, and what to write down.

WHAT PHYSICIANS TOLD ME

72%

would likely host a student if the right resources were in place.

65%

asked for students to arrive with an orientation handbook.

51%

said the chance to ask questions makes shadowing meaningful.

INSIDE

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01 Why Doctors Say No

KNOW THE BARRIERS BEFORE YOU ASK

A doctor who turns you down is rarely saying no to you. When I asked 43 physicians what gets in the way of hosting a high school student, their answers were about time, missing structure, and hospital rules. Once you know the obstacle, you can write a request that removes it.

79%

named lack of time, the most common barrier.

56%

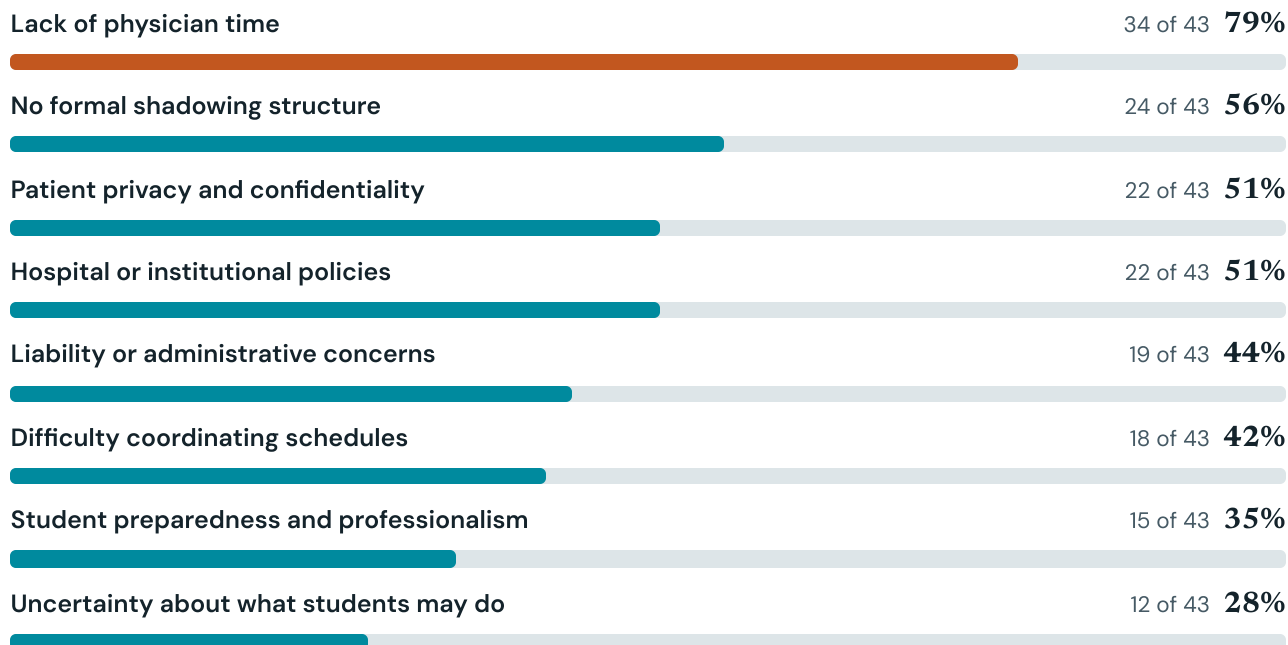
said no formal shadowing structure exists for them to follow.

51%

named hospital policies, and the same share named patient privacy.

Why doctors say no to high school students shadowing them

Share of 43 physicians selecting each



TURN EACH BARRIER INTO YOUR NEXT MOVE

IF THE BARRIER IS TIME

Ask for less

Request one half day. Offer three dates and let the office choose.

IF THE BARRIER IS STRUCTURE

Bring the plan

Say what you hope to observe and that you will follow their lead.

IF THE BARRIER IS POLICY

Ask the office first

Call the front desk and ask who approves student observers.

02 Find a Doctor to Shadow

START WITH PEOPLE WHO ALREADY KNOW YOU

Most shadowing days start with a personal connection. A physician is far more likely to answer a student they have some tie to than a stranger. Work outward from the people closest to you, and keep track of everyone you contact.

CLOSEST

Your own doctors

Your pediatrician, family doctor, or dentist already knows you. Ask at your next visit.

CLOSE

Family and friends

Ask parents, relatives, neighbors, and friends' parents who they know in medicine.

AT SCHOOL

Counselors and teachers

School counselors and science teachers often know alumni and local physicians.

IN TOWN

Private practices

Small clinics have fewer layers of approval than large hospitals. Call the office manager.

HOSPITALS

Volunteer offices

Many hospitals route student observers through a volunteer or education office.

PROGRAMS

Health career clubs

Groups such as HOSA and local health career programs can connect students with hosts.

63%

of the physicians I surveyed had already hosted a high school student.

27

physicians had hosted before. Ask a doctor who has and you skip the first-time worries.

16

had never hosted one. A short, prepared request matters most with them.

OUTREACH TRACKER

PHYSICIAN OR OFFICE	SPECIALTY	HOW I KNOW THEM	DATE ASKED	FOLLOW-UP	ANSWER

“

High school students shouldn't have to endlessly email physicians with no hope of finding any shadowing opportunities.

ZOHA WAHEED

03 How to Ask a Doctor to Shadow

A SHORT, SPECIFIC REQUEST IS EASIER TO SAY YES TO

Physicians read email between patients. Keep your request under 150 words, say exactly what you are asking for, and answer their worries before they have to raise them.

WHAT A GOOD REQUEST INCLUDES

- Who you are: name, school, and grade.
- Your connection: how you found them.
- Why them: one sentence on why their specialty interests you.
- A small ask: one half day, with flexible dates.
- Proof you are ready: you know the privacy rules and will complete any forms.
- An easy out: thank them either way.

Subject: High school student asking to shadow for a half day

Dear Dr. _____,

My name is _____ and I am a _____ at _____ High School. _____ suggested I contact you. I am considering a career in medicine and would like to learn what a day in _____ looks like.

Would you allow me to observe for one half day? I am free on _____, _____, or _____, and I can work around your schedule. I understand patient confidentiality and will complete any forms your office requires.

Thank you for considering it.

Sincerely, _____

Phone: _____

AFTER ONE WEEK

Follow up once

Reply to your own email with two sentences. Then call the office and ask for the manager.

AFTER TWO WEEKS

Move on politely

No answer usually means no time. Thank them and contact the next name on your list.

WHEN THEY SAY YES

Confirm in writing

Repeat the date, time, address, dress code, and who to ask for when you arrive.

BEFORE YOU PRESS SEND

- ☐ The doctor's name is spelled correctly
- ☐ The email is under 150 words
- ☐ My phone number is included
- ☐ A parent or teacher has read it

IF YOU CALL THE OFFICE INSTEAD

"Hello, my name is _____. I am a high school student interested in medicine. Could you tell me who handles requests to observe a physician, and the best way to reach them?"

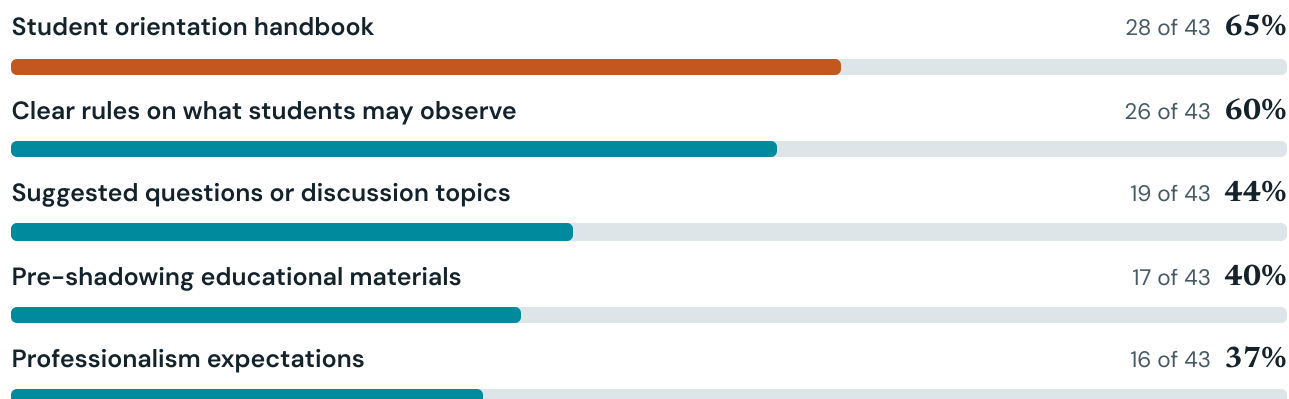
04 Before Your First Day

ARRIVE READY AND YOU REMOVE A DOCTOR'S BIGGEST DOUBT

Student preparedness worried 56% of the physicians who had never hosted a student, against 22% of those who had. The doctors asked for the fix themselves: students who arrive already oriented.

What physicians asked for

Share of 43 physicians requesting each resource



ASK THE OFFICE ABOUT PAPERWORK

- Age minimum: many hospitals set one, often 16.
- Confidentiality form: most require a signed agreement.
- Parent permission: expect a signature if you are under 18.
- Health records: some ask for immunizations or a TB test.
- Badge and parking: where to check in and where to park.

THE NIGHT BEFORE

- ☐ Forms signed and printed
- ☐ Notebook and two pens packed
- ☐ Address and contact name saved

LEARN THE BASICS FIRST

- The specialty: what it treats and who its patients are.
- Five common conditions: read a plain-language summary of each.
- Ten key terms: write them in the front of your notebook.
- The physician: read their practice's website.
- The route: plan to arrive 15 minutes early.

- ☐ Clothes laid out
- ☐ Questions written down
- ☐ Alarm set, breakfast planned

05 What to Wear to Shadow a Doctor

DRESS LIKE YOU WORK THERE

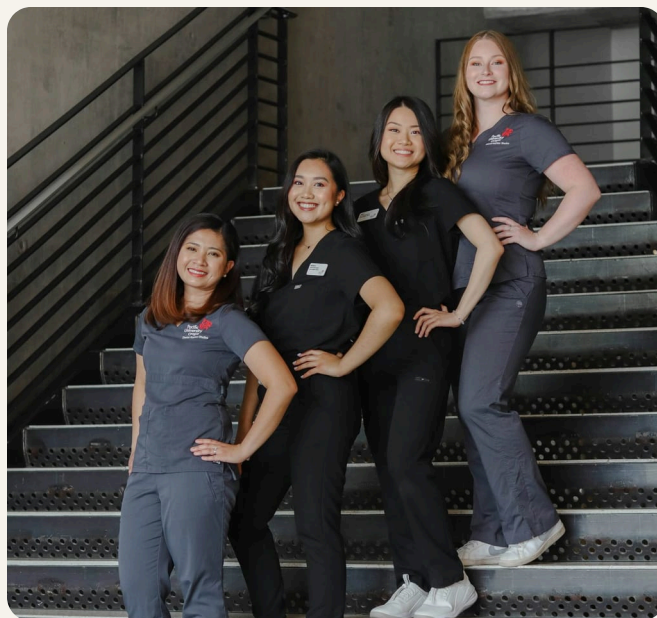
Patients will assume you are part of the team, so dress the part. Unless the office tells you otherwise, wear business casual. Save the scrubs for when someone hands them to you.

WEAR

- Business casual: slacks or a knee-length skirt with a collared shirt or blouse.
- Closed-toe shoes you can stand in for hours.
- Hair tied back if it is long.
- Scrubs only if the office asks for them.

LEAVE AT HOME

- Perfume or cologne. Patients may be sensitive to scent.
- Dangling jewelry and long necklaces.
- Jeans, shorts, and open-toe shoes.
- Anything with large logos or slogans.



SCRUBS

Change when you get there

Some surgical settings hand observers scrubs on arrival. Arrive in business casual and change on site.

WHITE COATS

Leave them to the staff

A white coat tells patients you are a clinician. Observers should not wear one.

BADGES

Keep yours visible

If the office gives you a visitor or observer badge, wear it where people can read it.

BRING

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Small notebook that fits a pocket | ☐ Two pens |
| ☐ Photo ID | ☐ Signed forms |
| ☐ Water bottle and a snack | ☐ Phone on silent, kept in your bag |

IF YOU FEEL FAINT

Feeling lightheaded during a first procedure is common and nothing to be embarrassed about. Eat breakfast, keep your knees unlocked, and if the room starts to tilt, sit down and tell someone right away.

06 Patient Privacy and Professionalism

THE RULES THAT KEEP YOU WELCOME

Every patient you see is trusting the room with private information. In the United States that trust is protected by a federal law called HIPAA. Half of the physicians I surveyed named privacy as a barrier to hosting students, so show them you take it seriously.

51%

of physicians named patient privacy as a barrier to hosting.

33%

asked for HIPAA and confidentiality training for students.

37%

asked for clear professionalism expectations.

ALWAYS

- Introduce yourself and let the patient decide if you stay.
- Step out the moment anyone asks you to.
- Stand where you are told and keep out of the way.
- Keep your notes free of names, birth dates, and room numbers.
- Wash or sanitize your hands going in and coming out.

NEVER

- Take photos or video, even of an empty room.
- Post about a patient, even without a name.
- Discuss a case in hallways, elevators, or at home.
- Touch a patient or equipment unless the physician asks.
- Offer medical opinions to a patient or family.

THREE TERMS TO KNOW

THE LAW

HIPAA

The federal law that protects the privacy of a patient's health information.

THE INFORMATION

PHI

Protected health information: anything that could identify a patient, from a name to a photo.

THE HABIT

Need to know

Only the people caring for a patient should hear the details. That rule applies to you too.

WHAT TO SAY WHEN YOU MEET A PATIENT

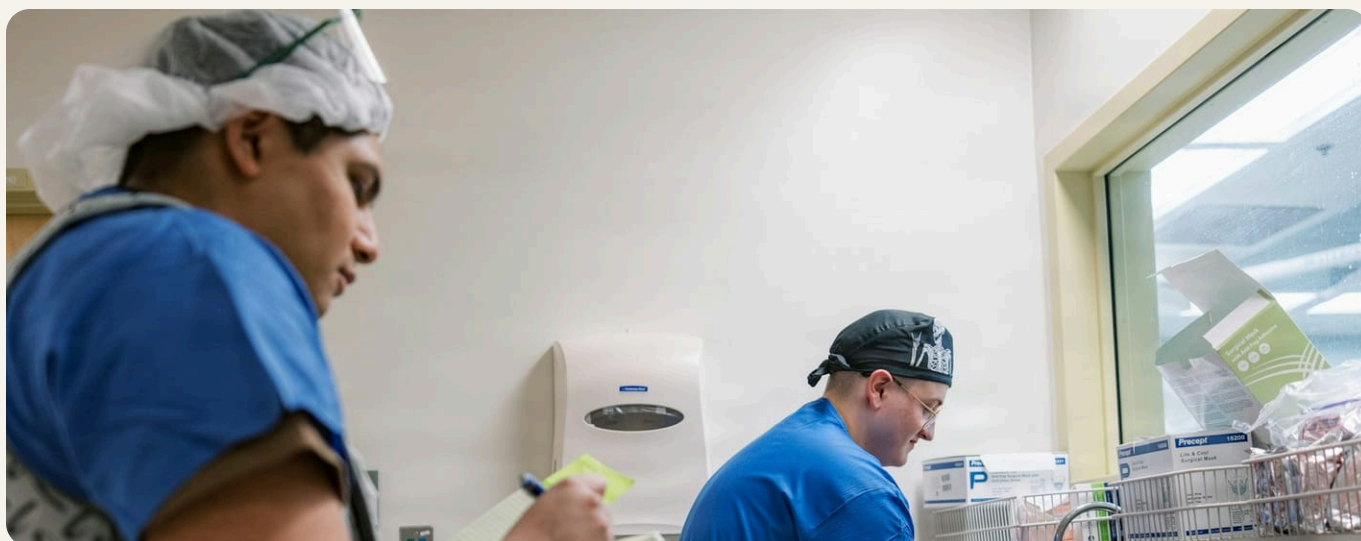
"Hello, my name is _____. I am a high school student observing Dr. _____ today. Is it all right with you if I stay in the room?"

If the patient says no, smile, thank them, and wait outside. It is their right, and physicians notice students who handle it well.

07 What to Do When Shadowing a Doctor

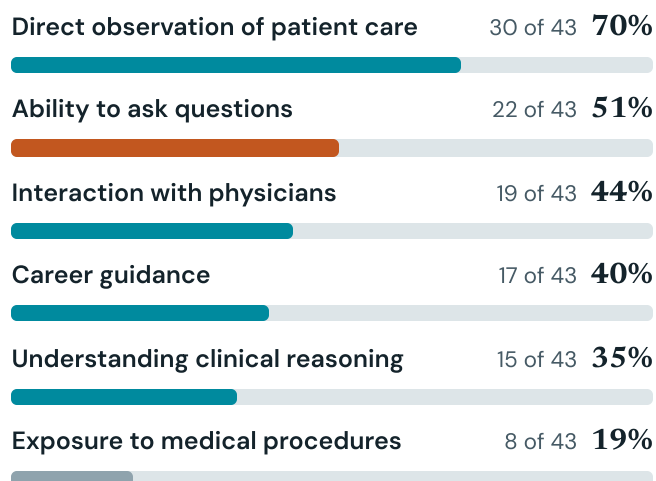
WATCH HOW A PHYSICIAN THINKS

Students often hope for a dramatic procedure. Physicians told me the value lies elsewhere: in watching patient care up close and understanding the reasoning behind it. Procedures ranked near the bottom.



What makes shadowing meaningful

Share of 43 physicians selecting each factor



WATCH FOR THESE SIX THINGS

- The opening: how the physician greets the patient and starts the visit.
- The history: which questions get asked, and in what order.
- The exam: what the physician checks and what gets skipped.
- The reasoning: what changed their mind along the way.
- The explanation: how a diagnosis is put in plain words.
- The team: who else helps, and what each person does.

SHADOW MORE THAN ONE SPECIALTY

A day in endocrinology looks nothing like a day in rheumatology. Seeing several specialties shows you different kinds of patients, problems, and pace, and it helps you picture where you fit.

08 Questions to Ask a Doctor You Shadow

ASK BETWEEN PATIENTS

More than half of the physicians I surveyed said the ability to ask questions is what makes shadowing meaningful. Write yours down before you arrive. Hold them until the patient has left, then ask while the visit is fresh.

ABOUT THE PATIENT YOU JUST SAW

- What information mattered most in making that decision?
- What possibilities were you considering?
- How did you decide which tests were necessary?
- What made this case difficult?



ABOUT THE WORK

- What does a typical week look like for you?
- Which parts of your job differ most from what students expect?
- What do you wish you had more time for?
- What is the hardest part of this specialty?

ABOUT THE PATH

- When did you know you wanted this specialty?
- What would you do differently in high school or college?
- What should I be doing now to prepare?
- Who else would you suggest I talk to or shadow?

TIMING

Between patients

Save questions for the hallway or the end of the day, never in front of a patient.

DEPTH

Ask why

Questions about reasoning teach you more than questions about facts you can look up.

LIMITS

Read the room

On a packed day, pick your best two questions and write the others down for later.

QUESTIONS TO SKIP

Leave out anything about salary, anything that names or identifies a patient, and anything a quick search could answer. Use your time with a physician for what only a physician can tell you.

09 After Each Day of Shadowing

WRITE IT DOWN WHILE IT IS FRESH

The studies I read agreed on one habit: reflection. Students who put their clinical experiences into writing analyze what they saw more carefully and notice what they still need to learn. Give yourself fifteen minutes the same evening.

SHADOWING JOURNAL

Date, physician, and specialty

What did I observe today? (no patient names)

What surprised me?

What did I learn about how this physician makes decisions?

What questions do I still have?

Could I see myself doing this work? Why or why not?

SEND A THANK-YOU NOTE WITHIN TWO DAYS

Dear Dr. _____,

Thank you for letting me shadow you on _____. Watching you _____ taught me _____. I especially appreciated the time you took to explain _____.

The day made me more certain that _____. Thank you again for your generosity.

Sincerely, _____

10 Ready to Shadow?

YOUR CHECKLIST, YOUR LOG, AND THE RESEARCH BEHIND THIS GUIDE

Physicians want to teach. Arrive prepared, ask good questions, and write down what you saw, and you will leave with a clearer answer about medicine than you came in with.

FINAL CHECKLIST

- ☐ I know who approves observers at this office
- ☐ I know the dress code
- ☐ My questions are written down
- ☐ My forms are signed
- ☐ I can explain the privacy rules
- ☐ My journal page is ready

SHADOWING LOG

DATE	PHYSICIAN	SPECIALTY	HOURS	ONE THING I LEARNED

THE SURVEY IN ONE GLANCE

79%

named lack of time as a barrier

72%

would likely host with the right resources

65%

asked for a student orientation handbook

51%

said asking questions makes shadowing meaningful

SOURCES

Waheed, Z. S. (2026). Physician perspectives on high school shadowing: Barriers, educational value, and opportunities for standardization. Survey of 43 practicing physicians. Abstract submitted to the 2027 Medical Education Innovation Conference.

Mann, K., Gordon, J., & MacLeod, A. (2009). Reflection and reflective practice in health professions education: A systematic review. *Advances in Health Sciences Education*, 14(4), 595–621.

Mafinejad, M. K., et al. (2022). Reflection on near-peer shadowing program. *BMC Medical Education*, 22.

Estes, M., et al. (2026). From fly on the wall to future colleagues: Best practice recommendations for medical student shadowing programs. *AEM Education and Training*, 10(3).

DEVELOPED BY ZOHA WAHEED

Shadow Pre-MD. Free for any student to use and share. Hospital rules vary, so always follow the instructions of the office hosting you.